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Ego-Involvement and the Third Person Effect of Televised News Coverage

Two experiments explored the interface between ego-involvement and the third person effect. In Experiment 1, 34 pro-Israeli, 34 pro-Palestinian, and 34 nonpartisan control-group subjects viewed televised news coverage of the 1982 war in Lebanon. As predicted, pro-Israeli and pro-Palestinian partisans believed that the news coverage would cause neutral viewers to become more unfavorable toward their side and more favorable toward their antagonists. Partisans also believed that neutral viewers would primarily recall facts that cast their side as the aggressor and their antagonists as the victim. A second experiment explored the accuracy of partisans' perceptions; participants in this study viewed the same news videotape that subjects watched in Experiment 1, and change in attitudes was assessed. The news coverage did not significantly influence subjects' attitudes toward Israel or the PLO, suggesting that involved partisans tend to exaggerate the magnitude and directional influence of mass media news coverage.

In contemporary society, mass media are generally believed to play an important role in the formation of the public's perceptions and attitudes. Much of the now-classic research on public opinion and mass communication takes the media as a starting point and then seeks to demonstrate that mass media influence the public's awareness or evaluation of an issue (cf. Becker, McCombs, & McLeod, 1975; McCombs, 1972). Yet, in a provocative article, Davison (1983) adopted a dramatically different approach, arguing that media effects may not be primarily due to the actual reactions of the intended audience of the message, but, instead, to the

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actions of those "who anticipate, or think they perceive, some reaction on the part of others" (p. 3).

Davison incorporated this notion under the rubric of the third person effect hypothesis. This hypothesis predicts individuals will overestimate the impact that mediated communications will exert on others. According to this view, individuals assume that communications will not have their greatest influence "on 'me' or 'you', but on 'them'—the third persons" (Davison, 1983, p. 3). A number of recent studies have investigated various facets of Davison's formulation (e.g., Glynn and Ostman, 1988; Lasorsa, 1987; Mutz, 1987; Thompson, Oshagan, & Chaffee, 1986). These investigations have focused primarily on the discrepancy between perceptions of communication effects on others and the self. Comparatively less attention has been focused on determining the conditions under which individuals are particularly inclined to expect that media will influence third persons. One important condition—suggested in Davison's article and by social psychological research (e.g., Lord, Ross, & Lepper, 1979)—is ego-involvement. Davison (1983) notes that

> one possible explanation for the fact that people on both sides of an issue can see the media as biased against their own point of view is that each observer assumes a disproportionate effect will be achieved by arguments or facts supporting the "wrong" side of the issue. Others (the third persons), the observer reasons, will be unduly impressed by these facts or arguments; they do not have the information that enables me to form a correct opinion. (p. 11)

Thus Davison suggests that ego-involved partisans will assume that mass media will sway third persons against their side. On the other hand, several lines of research make the opposite prediction—that is, under high involvement, individuals will believe that media reports will enhance agreement with their point of view. The purpose of the present article is to report the results of two experiments that attempt to shed light on the interface between ego-involvement and the third person effect.

Theoretical Underpinnings

Although Davison suggests that ego-involvement bears on the third person effect, he does not provide a theoretical underpinning for his ideas. Classic and contemporary studies in communication research and social cognition

offer a more theoretical foundation. They suggest two mechanisms underlie the tendency of ego-involved individuals to perceive that mass media reports will sway public opinion against their side: involved individuals' proclivity to harbor biased perceptions of media content and the general tendency to overestimate the effects that mediated messages exert on the audience (i.e., the third person effect).

BIASED PERCEPTIONS OF MEDIA CONTENT

There is little question that individuals selectively interpret information so that it conforms with their strongly held beliefs (Allport & Postman, 1945; Cannell & MacDonald, 1956; Hastorf & Cantril, 1954; Klapper, 1960; Stevenson & Greene, 1980). More recent studies make it quite clear that when individuals have a strong prior commitment to a position, they assimilate or find support in evidence and information that other people regard as ambiguous, inconclusive, and problem ridden (Lord et al., 1979; Nisbett & Ross, 1980).

Thus, under high involvement, individuals should be loathe to change their minds, no matter how cogent or compelling the information. In the case of American news—the focus of the present studies—the information is typically structured so as to present both sides of a controversial issue (e.g., Epstein, 1973). Rather than changing their beliefs as a function of what they see, involved individuals should simply perceive that the news is unfairly biased against their side and in favor of their antagonists.

THIRD PERSON EFFECT

Consistent with the third person effect hypothesis, recent studies have found that individuals overestimate the impact that mediated communications exert on others (Lasorsa, 1987; Mutz, 1987; Perloff et al., 1987). In an experimental study, Collins, Taylor, Wood, and Thompson (1988) found that subjects perceived both vivid and nonvivid messages would influence other people more than themselves.

Thus one may expect that involved partisans will perceive that psychologically relevant media reports are biased against their side and, like other individuals, will overestimate the impact that these reports exert on third persons. If one assumes these two mechanisms operate in an additive

fashion, this suggests that when individuals are highly involved in media coverage of an issue, they should come to believe that media reports will sway third persons against their side.

Yet it is also possible to formulate an opposing hypothesis based on studies of the false consensus effect (e.g., Ross, Greene, & House, 1977). The false consensus effect is the tendency to overestimate the typicality of one's opinions, or to assume that other individuals will feel, believe, and behave exactly as one does (Fields & Schuman, 1976; Ross et al, 1977; Zuckerman, Mann, & Bernieri, 1982). The false consensus effect suggests that when individuals are ego-involved in media reports, they will assume that others will share their interpretations of the media coverage. Because they perceive the reports are biased, they should assume that others will do the same. Because their views have been reinforced by what they have seen, they should expect that others' beliefs will also be similarly strengthened. Thus, rather than assuming that third persons will be swayed in the opposite direction of their own beliefs, involved individuals should contend that third persons will be influenced in the same direction and manner as themselves.

The problem with this formulation is the assumption that involved individuals will perceive that audience members—that is, third persons—are similar to them. This assumption may be open to question in the case of perceptions of the impact that persuasive messages exert on the mass media audience. Theorists argue that an individual (P) will project his or her beliefs onto another (O) only if he or she perceives that O is similar to P in relevant background attributes (Allport, 1924; Goethals & Darley, 1977; Orive, 1988). However, an individual may be relatively unlikely to presume that he or she shares similar attributes with members of the "mass audience." An individual may believe that the audience is passive, gullible, and manipulable (Smith, 1986) while regarding himself or herself as unique and impervious to influence (Weinstein, 1980). Or an individual may prefer to believe for ego-defensive reasons that he or she is different from and superior to mass audience members. Recent studies of the third person effect have obtained evidence consistent with this line of thinking. Rather than finding that individuals perceive media reports to exert similar effects on others as on themselves, these studies have consistently reported the opposite finding: Individuals appear to assume that mass audience members are different from themselves, for they perceive that media reports and persuasive communications exert a substantially greater

impact on others than on themselves (e.g., Collins et al., 1988; Lasorsa, 1987).

One might argue that individuals will be even more inclined to "contrast" their interpretations from those of the audience under high ego-involvement, given that involvement invariably accentuates and distorts social perceptions (Petty & Cacioppo, 1981). Consistent with this hypothesis, Fields and Schuman (1976) reported that although the overwhelming majority of their sample believed that others would share their position on racial issues, those with a strong liberal ideology believed that the public held a more conservative position on these issues than did they.

EGO-INVOLVEMENT AND THIRD PERSON PERCEPTIONS

A recent study by Vallone, Ross, and Lepper (1985) provided a more direct test of the hypothesis that involvement influences perceptions of media effects. Vallone et al. found that pro-Israeli partisans perceived that neutral viewers would become more negative to Israel after viewing televised coverage of the 1982 Beirut massacre, whereas pro-Arab partisans believed that neutral viewers would become more positive to Israel. As intriguing as these results are, they are somewhat weakened by the finding that control-group subjects' perceptions closely resembled those of pro-Israeli partisans.

The investigators did find that the more knowledge that control-group subjects had about the conflict, the less likely they were to resemble Israeli partisans. However, the aforementioned findings with their original subject group raise the possibility that the pro-Israeli subjects' perceptions did not reflect a skewed or biased perception of media effects but, rather, conformed with what most people would say. It suggests that the stimulus materials may have reflected an anti-Israel bias that all but the most strident opponents of Israel would have to acknowledge. In addition, Vallone et al. (1985) assessed only perceptions of the impact that media coverage would exert on neutral viewers' attitudes toward Israel. A more complete examination of this facet of the third person effect hypothesis would assess beliefs about how the media coverage influenced neutral viewers' attitudes toward both sides of the conflict—that is, toward the Arab as well as the Israeli side.

Thus the present studies were designed to provide a more compelling test of the hypothesis that ego-involvement influences the direction of the

third person effect by setting in motion biased perceptions about the impact that mass media exerts on the audience. These experiments sought to extend Vallone et al.'s (1985) study by examining the breadth, range, and accuracy of partisans' perceptions of media effects.

It is important to emphasize that the experiments reported in this article focused on ego-involvement, as distinct from other conceptualizations of involvement—for example, salience (Mulder, 1979); personal relevance (Petty, Cacioppo, & Goldman, 1981); or a characteristic of the situation (Bowen & Chaffee, 1974). Of all the concepts of involvement, ego-involvement seemed to best capture what Davison had in mind in his original article when he argued that "*people on both sides of an issue* [italics added]" assume that a "disproportionate effect will be achieved by arguments or facts supporting the 'wrong' side of the issue" (1983, p. 11). Conceptually, ego-involvement is defined as the arousal of the individual's commitments in the context of appropriate situations (Sherif, Sherif, & Nebergall, 1965; cf. Salmon, 1986). According to Sherif's classical approach to ego-involvement (Sherif & Cantril, 1947), ego-involved attitudes are an important component of the individual's self-image; indeed, they are linked to the person's central values and constructs and ordinarily consist of strongly held commitments to family, politics, or religion (Sherif et al., 1965).

The Present Study

Ego-involvement in the Middle East conflict seemed a particularly appropriate context for the present investigation. There is little question that supporters of the Arab and Israeli causes have deep and abiding commitments to their positions. In addition, by focusing on the Middle East conflict we can build on the earlier findings of Vallone et al. (1985). The present experiments focused directly on the television coverage of the 1982 war in Lebanon because this aroused considerable controversy in the journalistic community, as well as among Arabs and Jews (Morris, 1982; Muravchik, 1983; Roeh & Ashley 1986; Shipler, 1986).

Six hypotheses were formulated. The first prediction followed from the previously reviewed literature on involvement and selective interpretation of information.

Hypothesis 1a: Pro-Israeli partisans will be more likely than pro-Palestinian partisans and a control group of nonpartisans to perceive

that the news coverage is biased against Israel and in favor of the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO).

Hypothesis 1b: Pro-Palestinian partisans will be more likely than pro-Israeli partisans and a control group of nonpartisans to believe that the news coverage is biased against the PLO and in favor of Israel.

Second, to the extent that partisans perceive that the news reflects unfavorably on their side, they can be expected to attribute hostile intentions to the journalists who prepared and delivered the message. As Mutz (1987) notes, based on Worth and Gross's (1974) theory of symbolic strategies, second persons may believe that they alone understand the sender's motives—in their view, while third persons naively regard the news as *information* that is fair and objective, they alone are sufficiently sophisticated to recognize that the news is actually akin to *propaganda.* Given that ego-involvement induces distortions in social perception, one may expect involved partisans to be particularly likely to exhibit what Nasby, Hayden, and DePaulo (1980) refer to as an attributional bias to infer hostility. This leads to the following prediction:

Hypothesis 2a: Pro-Israeli partisans will be more likely than pro-Palestinian partisans and nonpartisan controls to believe that the news coverage reflects a journalistic bias against Jews and in favor of Arabs.

Hypothesis 2b: Pro-Palestinian partisans will be more likely than pro-Israeli partisans and nonpartisan controls to believe that the news coverage reflects a journalistic bias against Arabs and in favor of Jews.

The third hypothesis was derived from the previously discussed literature on ego-involvement, selective perception, and the third person effect.

Hypothesis 3a: Pro-Israeli partisans will be more likely than pro-Palestinian partisans and nonpartisan controls to perceive that the news coverage will cause a neutral audience to feel less favorably toward Israel and more favorably toward the PLO.

Hypothesis 3b: Pro-Palestinian partisans will be more likely than pro-Israeli partisans and nonpartisan controls to believe that the news coverage will cause a neutral audience to feel less favorably toward the PLO and more favorably toward Israel.

The next set of predictions was based on studies of priming (e.g., Higgins, King, & Mavin, 1982; Srull & Wyer, 1974) and the spreading-activation hypothesis (Collins & Loftus, 1975). These studies have documented the many ways in which prior context can influence the interpretation, processing, and retrieval of information. Collins and Loftus's experiments on the spreading-activation hypothesis have shown that when a particular concept is activated, other linked concepts are made automatically accessible (see also Iyengar & Kinder, 1987). This suggests that when perceptions of bias against Israel or the PLO are activated, other related constructs should also come to mind—that is, perceptions of Israel or the PLO as the aggressor rather than victim in the Middle East and stereotypes of Jews and Arabs.

Hypothesis 4a: Pro-Israeli partisans will perceive that the news coverage will cause a neutral audience to regard Israel as the aggressor and the PLO as the victim to a greater extent than will pro-Palestinian partisans and nonpartisan controls.

Hypothesis 4b: Pro-Palestinian partisans will perceive that the news coverage will cause a neutral audience to regard the PLO as the aggressor and Israel as the victim to a greater extent than will pro-Israeli partisans and nonpartisan controls.

Hypothesis 5a: Pro-Israeli partisans will be more likely than pro-Palestinian partisans and nonpartisan controls to perceive that the news coverage will cause a neutral audience to feel less favorably toward Jews and more favorably toward Arabs.

Hypothesis 5b: Pro-Palestinian partisans will be more likely than pro-Israeli partisans and nonpartisan controls to perceive that the news coverage will cause a neutral audience to feel less favorably toward Arabs and more favorably toward Jews.

The first five predictions were tested by examining responses to a series of closed-ended measures of perceived media effects. A corollary hypothesis derived from the same theoretical rationale was formulated in order to examine perceptions in a more dynamic and open-ended way.

Hypothesis 6a: Pro-Israeli partisans will be more likely than pro-Palestinian partisans and nonpartisan controls to believe that students will remember events that reflect negatively on Israel and positively on the PLO.

Hypothesis 6b: Pro-Palestinian partisans will be more likely than pro-Israeli partisans and nonpartisan controls to perceive that students will remember events that reflect negatively on the PLO and positively on Israel.

Experiment 1

Method

STIMULUS MATERIALS

A 13-min, 30-sec videotape was constructed to depict the 1982 war between Israel and its Arab enemies, chiefly the PLO. The videotape was constructed by assembling news footage from CBS, NBC, and ABC coverage of the 1982 Lebanon war. The materials were selected after an exhaustive search of television coverage of the 1982 war using the Vanderbilt University Television Archives. Literally hours and hours of footage were viewed, and were discarded or selected based on quantitative content analyses of news coverage of the war (Paraschos & Rutherford, 1985) and partisan criticism of media coverage (e.g., Alexander, 1982; Muravchik, 1983). Materials were selected in order to ensure that Israel and the PLO were portrayed as both aggressors and victims. Pretesting helped to ensure that there were approximately equal numbers of incidents in which Israel and the PLO were depicted as the perpetrators and the victims of aggressive acts. For example, two reports depicted Israeli aggression, showing graphic scenes of civilian casualties and property damage that resulted from Israeli bombing of Beirut. In contrast, other news clips focused on PLO aggression such as a 1982 attack on a Jewish synagogue in Rome that sources attributed to the PLO.

PROCEDURE AND MEASURES

Participants were told that they would view a videotape depicting problems in the Middle East; it was explained that their feedback would be useful in developing and perfecting the videotape. After watching the news videotape, subjects answered a series of closed-ended and open-ended survey questions.

Ego-involvement has been classically operationalized by identifying the individual's salient group memberships and then determining his or her latitude of acceptance and rejection on issues relevant to the group (Sherif et al., 1965). Thus ego-involved individuals should strongly identify with a partisan group and should possess extreme positions on the issues relevant to the group. Following this general procedure, pro-Israeli and pro-Palestinian subjects were recruited from partisan Jewish and Arab student groups at six public and private universities located in a midwestern state. Pro-Israeli college students were also recruited from a regional Jewish youth organization. Israeli participants were in almost all cases Orthodox Jews, and pro-Palestinian partisans were Moslems. Control-group subjects were students at a public university in the same state.

Survey measures documented that pro-Israeli and pro-Arab subjects strongly identified with their respective partisan groups. Group identification was documented by asking subjects to locate "me" on two 100-point scales on which Israel and the PLO were 100. The closer to 100 they placed "me," the more strongly they identified with Israel and the PLO, respectively. Pro-Israeli partisans identified significantly more with Israel ($M = 89.09$) than did pro-Palestinian ($M = 1.30$) or control-group ($M = 28.82$) subjects ($p < .01$). Pro-Palestinian partisans identified more strongly with the PLO ($M = 83.67$) than did pro-Israeli ($M = 7.83$) or control-group subjects ($M = 24.83$, $p < .01$).

Pretest measures also documented that partisans held extremely positive attitudes toward their side and extremely negative opinions of their antagonists. Two 11-point scales tapped attitudes toward Israel and the PLO, with 1 signifying a *very favorable* and 11 a *very unfavorable attitude.* Pro-Israeli partisans held highly favorable attitudes toward Israel ($M = 1.32$) and highly unfavorable opinions of the PLO ($M = 10.82$). Pro-Palestinian partisans were highly favorable to the PLO ($M = 1.91$) and very unfavorable to Israel ($M = 10.91$). Control-group participants held approximately equal attitudes toward both groups (Israel mean = 6.65; PLO mean = 7.26). The differences among pro-Israeli, pro-Palestinian partisans, and control-group subjects' attitudes toward Israel and the PLO were highly significant ($ps < .001$).

After watching the news videotape, subjects answered a series of closed-ended and open-ended questions. The first set of questions, adapted from Vallone et al. (1985), asked subjects to indicate on a series of 11-point scales

how fair or unfair the tape was and the extent to which it displayed bias toward Israel and the PLO. Subjects also estimated the percentage of references that were anti-PLO and anti-Israel. Attributions of hostile intent were assessed by asking respondents to indicate the extent to which they believed that the news coverage reflected subtle anti-Arab and anti-Jewish biases on the part of editors and reporters. The next questions asked subjects to indicate on 11-point scales the impact they believed the news coverage would exert on neutral viewers' attitudes toward Israel, the PLO, Jews, and Arabs. Order of questions was varied so that in half the cases the first question in a two-question set concerned Israel and in the other half of the cases the first question concerned the PLO.

PERCEIVED RECALL MEASURES

Subjects were also asked to list the facts from the videotape that they thought most college students would remember. Room for seven such responses was provided. Two coders subsequently classified these open-ended responses into five categories of perceived recall. Interrater agreement was 88%.

The first category, *Israel as aggressor*, consisted of beliefs that students would remember that Israel committed aggressive or hostile actions (i.e., most students would remember "the violence of the Israelis against the Lebanese"). The second category, the flip side of *Israel as aggressor*, was *PLO as victim*. This consisted of beliefs that students would recall the PLO or Palestinians as victims, or that they would remember that Palestinians were depicted in a sympathetic manner by the news coverage (i.e., most students would remember that "media tried to make us feel sorry for the Palestinians who were bombed by showing us the pitiful sights"). The third category, *PLO as aggressor*, was typified by the belief that students would remember PLO aggression (i.e., most students would remember that "the PLO shot or started shooting Israeli civilians and cities"). *Israel as victim*, the fourth category, encompassed beliefs that students would remember that the news coverage depicted Israel as the victim of PLO aggression or would recall sympathetic references to Israel (i.e., most students would remember "northern Israeli towns being bombed"). The fifth category, *random violence*, referred to beliefs that students would recall random acts of violence or inhumanity yet would not attribute this violence to either side

(i.e., most students would remember "civilian casualties" and "demolished cities").

Statistical Analyses

A multivariate analysis of variance using Pillai-Bartlett's trace was performed on the closed-ended dependent variable questions (see Bray & Maxwell, 1985; Bochner & Fitzpatrick, 1980). Univariate F-tests and Newman-Keuls tests were performed to clarify the nature of significant group differences.

In order to analyze open-ended responses (i.e., Hypothesis 6), five sets of proportions were constructed—one for each of the five categories of perceived recall. The number of facts that a subject believed students would remember from each category served as the numerator, and the total number of facts this subject believed students would recall served as the denominator. Although most subjects listed some facts, within categories distributions were skewed. This occurred because only a minority of the subjects listed more than one fact within a given category. Arc sin transformations were applied, inasmuch as this procedure helps to reduce skewness in proportion scores (Winer, 1971). The transformed proportions in turn were the dependent variables of a multivariate analysis of variance that also used Pillai-Bartlett's trace. Once again, univariate F tests and Newman-Keuls tests were subsequently performed.

Results

The multivariate analysis of variance performed on the closed-ended dependent variables yielded highly significant results, $F(26, 176) = 7.98$, $p < .001$. Univariate F tests performed on each dependent variable were also significant.

Perceived Bias and Intent

Five univariate F tests were performed to test group differences in perceptions of fairness and bias in news coverage. There was a significant main effect for perceived fairness of the news coverage, $F(2, 99) = 7.29$, $p < .001$. Post hoc Newman-Keuls tests indicated that pro-Israeli and pro-

Table 1
Pro-Israeli, Pro-Palestinian, and Control Group Subjects' Mean Perceptions of News Media Bias

	Subject group					
	Pro-Israeli		Pro-Palestinian		Control group	
Variable	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*
Perceived fairness of news coverage	4.41_a	2.43	3.91_a	2.50	6.03_b	2.24
Belief news is negative to Israel	8.12_a	1.81	2.59_b	1.23	6.00_c	1.97
Belief news is negative to PLO	4.50_a	2.36	9.32_b	1.53	6.85_c	1.91
Perceived percentage of news negative to Israel*	61.00_a	21.78	20.15_b	15.25	49.03_a	20.79
Perceived percentage of news negative to PLO	28.56_a	22.97	73.53_b	22.17	56.15_c	20.16
Attribution of anti-Jewish sentiments to editors	8.03_a	2.49	2.59_b	2.41	5.82_c	2.26
Attribution of anti-Arab sentiments to editors	3.88_a	2.65	8.59_b	2.36	6.62_c	2.53

Note. $n = 34$ for all groups. Means with different subscripts differ significantly at $p < .01$. *Pro-Israeli group and control differ significantly at $p < .05$. Higher numbers signify higher scores on the item.

Palestinian partisans perceived that the news coverage was significantly less fair than did control-group partisans. However, as Table 1 shows, pro-Palestinian and pro-Israeli partisans did not differ in the extent to which they judged the news to be unfair.

The main effects for perceived bias against Israel $F(2, 99) = 91.68$, $p < .001$, and for perceived bias against the PLO, $F(2, 99) = 51.24$, $p < .001$, were highly significant. Post hoc tests for the two measures indicated that the three group means differed significantly from each other. These differences were in the predicted direction. Pro-Israeli partisans perceived that the news coverage was more biased against Israel than did pro-Palestinian partisans and nonpartisans controls. Pro-Palestinian partisans believed that the news was more biased against the PLO than did pro-Israeli or control-group subjects. Thus Hypothesis 1 was supported.

Table 2
Pro-Israeli, Pro-Palestinian, and Control Group Subjects' Mean Perceptions of News Media Effects

	Subject group					
	Pro-Israeli		Pro-Palestinian		Control group	
Variable	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*
Perceived impact on attitudes toward Israel	8.41_a	1.37	4.68_b	2.77	6.65_c	2.52
Perceived impact on attitudes toward PLO*	4.94_a	1.98	8.50_b	2.03	7.35_b	2.47
Perceived impact on ratings of Israel as aggressor	8.97_a	1.60	4.21_b	2.68	6.00_c	2.97
Perceived impact on ratings of PLO as aggressor	4.35_a	2.36	8.62_b	2.12	6.91_c	2.70
Perceived impact on attitudes toward Jews	7.44_a	1.58	4.47_b	2.25	5.88_c	1.79
Perceived impact on attitudes toward Arabs	4.71_a	1.51	7.50_b	2.21	7.03_b	1.66

Note. $n = 34$ for all groups. Means with different subscripts differ significantly at $p < .01$. *Pro-Palestinian group and control differ significantly at $p < .05$. Higher numbers signify higher scores on the item.

Furthermore, there were significant between-group differences in estimates of the proportion of the news that cast the PLO, $F(2, 99) = 36.79$, $p < .001$, and Israel, $F(2, 99) = 39.48$, $p < .001$, in a negative light. Newman-Keuls tests for the two measures indicated that the means differed significantly from each other. Differences were in the predicted direction. Pro-Palestinian partisans contended that more of the news placed the PLO in a negative light than did pro-Israeli or control-group subjects. In a parallel fashion, pro-Israeli partisans' estimates of the proportion of references that were unfavorable to Israel significantly exceeded those of pro-Palestinian and control-group participants.

The second hypothesis also received strong support from the data. The three subject groups differed significantly in their perception that the news coverage reflected a journalistic bias against Arabs, $F(2, 99) = 29.95$, $p < .001$, and against Jews, $F(2, 99) = 44.53$, $p < .001$. Post hoc tests for the two measures indicated that each of the three means differed significantly from

each other. As predicted, pro-Palestinian partisans were more likely than pro-Israeli or control-group subjects to believe that the news reflected a journalistic bias against Arabs, while pro-Israeli supporters were more likely than subjects in the other two groups to perceive that the coverage reflected a journalistic prejudice against Jews.

THIRD PERSON EFFECT

Partisan and control-group subjects differed significantly in their perceptions of the effects that the news coverage would exert on neutral viewers. There was a significant main effect for perceptions of the news videotape's impact on attitudes toward Israel, $F(2, 99) = 22.30$, $p < .001$, and on attitudes toward the PLO, $F(2, 99) = 23.72$, $p < .001$. Newman-Keuls tests revealed that the three group means significantly differed from each other. As predicted, pro-Israeli partisans believed that the news coverage would cause a neutral audience to become less favorable to Israel than did pro-Palestinian or control-group participants. Pro-Palestinian partisans were more likely than control-group or pro-Israeli subjects to perceive that neutral persons would become less favorable to the PLO after watching the 13-min videotape. These results offered strong support for Hypothesis 3.

The fourth and fifth hypotheses, derived from priming theory, received generally strong support from the data. The three groups differed significantly in their belief that the news coverage would cause neutral viewers to regard the PLO as the aggressor rather than the victim, $F(2, 99) = 27.09$, $p < .001$, and to perceive Israel as the aggressor rather than the victim $F(2, 99) = 31.72$, $p < .001$. Newman-Keuls tests for both measures revealed that each of the group means differed significantly from each other, with differences in the predicted direction. Consistent with the hypothesis, pro-Palestinian partisans believed that the news coverage would cause a neutral audience to regard the PLO as the aggressor rather than the victim to a significantly greater extent than did pro-Israeli or control-group subjects. In precisely the same fashion, pro-Israeli partisans were more likely than pro-Palestinian or control-group subjects to contend that neutral viewers would consider Israel as the aggressor rather than the victim after viewing the 13-min news videotape.

There were also significant main effects for perceptions of the news coverage's impact on attitudes toward Jews, $F(2, 99) = 20.97$, $p < .001$, and

Arabs $F(2, 99) = 23.07$, $p < .001$. Post hoc tests indicated that in the case of attitudes toward Jews, the group means differed significantly from each other. As predicted, pro-Israeli partisans perceived that students would become significantly less favorable toward Jews than did Palestinian partisans or control-group subjects. Post hoc tests on attitudes toward Arabs indicated that pro-Israeli subjects believed that students would become significantly more favorable toward Arabs than did pro-Palestinian or control-group subjects; however, pro-Palestinian partisans did not perceive that students would become significantly less favorable toward Arabs than did control-group subjects.

Perceptions of Viewers' Recall

Hypothesis 6 predicted that partisans would have biased perceptions of the types of information viewers would recall from the newscast. The multivariate test, utilizing Pillai-Bartlett's trace, yielded a highly significant effect $F(10, 186) = 14.52$, $p < .001$. Univariate F tests were subsequently performed, and each of these also proved to be significant. Table 3 displays these results; for purposes of clarity, mean proportions have been presented prior to transformations.

As Table 3 shows, there were significant group differences in the proportional number of *Israel-as-aggressor*, $F(2, 96) = 19.68$, $p < .001$, and *PLO-as-victim*, $F(2, 96) = 16.86$, $p < .001$, responses. Newman-Keuls tests indicated that pro-Israeli partisans' proportional estimates in both these categories were significantly higher than those of pro-Palestinian and control-group subjects; however, pro-Palestinian and control-group subjects did not significantly differ on these measures. In essence, pro-Israeli subjects believed that students would remember that Israel was the aggressor and the PLO the victim to a greater degree than subjects in the other two conditions.

There were also significant group differences in the proportional number of *PLO-as-aggressor*, $F(2, 96) = 13.45$, $p < .001$, and *Israel-as-victim*, $F(2, 96) = 17.42$, $p < .001$), responses. Post hoc tests revealed that pro-Palestinian partisans' proportional estimates in both these categories significantly exceeded those of pro-Israeli and control-group subjects; however, pro-Israeli and control-group subjects did not differ significantly on these measures. In effect, pro-Palestinian partisans perceived that

Table 3
Mean Beliefs of Pro-Israeli, Pro-Palestinian, and Control Group Subjects as to What Viewers Will Remember from News Coverage

Item and illustrative response	Subject group: Pro-Israeli *M*	Pro-Israeli *SD*	Pro-Palestinian *M*	Pro-Palestinian *SD*	Control group *M*	Control group *SD*
Israel as aggressor ("Bombing, bombing, bombing by Israel")	$.24_a$	.19	$.06_b$	.11	$.05_b$	.10
PLO as victim ("Homes demolished, refugee status of Palestinians")	$.18_a$	.18	$.03_b$	.08	$.02_b$	.07
PLO as aggressor ("The PLO started shooting Israeli civilians and cities")	$.04_b$	.11	$.23_a$	.25	$.05_b$	.09
Israel as victim ("Northern Israel towns being bombed")	$.08_b$	.12	$.32_a$	.30	$.05_b$	.10
Random violence ("Continuing destruction of West Beirut")*	$.21_a$	.25	$.14_b$	.24	$.38_a$	.33

Note: n = 34 for pro-Israeli group, n = 32 for pro-Palestinian group, n = 33 for control group. Means with different subscripts differ significantly at $p < .01$.
*Control and pro-Israeli group differ significantly at $p < .05$. Higher numbers signify higher scores on the item.

students would recall that the PLO was the aggressor and Israel the victim to a significantly greater degree than subjects in the other two groups. These results were consistent with the predictions made by Hypothesis 6.

Lastly, there were between-group differences in the perception that students would remember random violence, $F(2, 96) = 5.56$, $p < .005$. Post hoc Newman-Keuls tests revealed that this effect was due to the fact that control-group subjects' proportional estimates in this category were significantly higher than those of pro-Israeli and pro-Palestinian partisans. In other words, control-group subjects were most inclined to believe that students would recall incidents that depicted the violence and inhumanity of the war in the Middle East—incidents that were not attributed to either Israel or the PLO.

Taken as a whole, these findings clearly demonstrate that partisans perceive that news media coverage will cause third persons to become less favorable toward their positions on the Middle East issue. However, these results do not address the *accuracy* of partisans' beliefs. This is an important issue, inasmuch as the research on ego-involvement and the third person effect suggests that ego-involved partisans should overestimate the magnitude and directional influence of media effects.

There is anecdotal and empirical evidence from the 1982 Lebanon war controversy that is consistent with this idea. At that time, pro-Israeli partisans argued that media coverage of the war was heavily biased against Israel and would permanently tarnish Americans' attitudes toward Israel (see Alexander, 1982; Morris, 1982). However, in a recent content analysis of media coverage of the war, Paraschos and Rutherford (1985) found that although more of reporters' nonneutral statements were anti-Israel than anti-PLO, over three-fourths of their assertions were judged to be neutral. In addition, contrary to many pro-Israeli activists' claims in 1982, Gilboa (1987) reported that although public opinion toward Israel did drop in the 6-month period that followed the 1982 war, it returned to its prewar levels by February 1983.

These examples informally suggest that partisans' perceptions of media effects do not closely conform with actual media impact. A more persuasive test of the inaccuracy notion would involve a comparison of partisans' perceptions of media effects with evidence of *actual* media impact. A second experiment was conducted to examine this issue.

Experiment 2

Method

SUBJECTS

Students recruited from communication classes at a midwestern state university participated in the second experiment. The 24 subjects randomly assigned to the experimental group viewed the same 13-min, 30-sec videotape on the Lebanon war that subjects watched in Experiment 1. The 24 subjects assigned to the control-group watched a 13-min excerpt from a Public Broadcasting System program on political advertising narrated by Bill Moyers.

PROCEDURE AND QUESTIONNAIRE

Subjects first completed a pretest survey of international communications that assessed their exposure to international news and their attitudes toward several foreign countries. Two questions tapping attitudes toward the PLO and Israel were embedded in the survey. A week after completing the pretest survey, subjects viewed either the experimental or the control videotape. Attitudes toward Israel and the PLO were assessed again. Subjects were also asked four additional questions tapping attitudes toward Arabs and Jews and perception of Israel and the PLO as victim or aggressor. Finally, students listed the facts and events that they remembered from the videotape. Their responses were classified using the five-category coding scheme described above.

STATISTICAL ANALYSES

In order to assess the effects that the news coverage exerted on attitudes toward the PLO and Israel, a one-way analysis of covariance was performed on posttest attitudes toward the PLO and Israel, controlling for pretest attitudes; t tests were performed on the four other dependent variable questions.

Open-ended recall responses were analyzed by constructing five sets of proportions, with the number of facts a subject recalled within each category serving as the numerator and the total number of facts the denominator. Arc sin transformations were then performed on these scores, and the transformed variables became the dependent variables in a one-way within-subjects analysis of variance (cf. Winer, 1971).

Results

The news coverage did not change attitudes toward either Israel or the PLO (Fs < 1.8). The results of four t tests indicated that subjects who viewed the news coverage did not differ from control-group subjects in their attitudes toward Arabs and Jews or in their perceptions of which side was the aggressor in the Middle East conflict (Fs < 1.5).

An ANOVA performed on recall scores yielded highly significant results, $F(4, 88) = 8.46$, $p < .001$, and Newman-Keuls tests clarified the

nature of this effect. Two sets of comparisons proved to be significant. Subjects recalled a significantly higher proportion of *Israel-as-aggressor* facts than *PLO-as-victim* facts ($p < .05$). Of greater interest was the finding that the mean proportion of facts pertaining to random violence significantly exceeded the mean proportion of facts in each of the other four categories ($ps < .01$). Thus students recalled a significantly greater proportion of facts pertaining to *random violence* ($M = .28$) than they did facts pertaining to *Israel as aggressor* ($M = .13$), *Israel as victim* ($M = .10$), *PLO as aggressor* ($M = .09$), and *PLO as victim* ($M = .03$).

General Discussion

The findings demonstrated that ego-involvement powerfully influences perceptions of communication effects. As hypothesized, pro-Israeli and pro-Palestinian partisans perceived that the news was strongly and unfairly biased against their side and in favor of their antagonists; they also believed that the news coverage reflected a journalistic prejudice against their ethnic group. Consistent with the third person effect/involvement hypothesis, pro-Israeli partisans were more likely than pro-Palestinian or control-group subjects to believe that neutral viewers would become less favorable to Israel and more favorable to the PLO; in contrast, pro-Palestinian partisans believed that neutral individuals would evaluate the PLO less positively and Israel more positively than did pro-Israeli or control-group subjects. Using more open-ended perceptual measures, we found that partisans from both groups believed that neutral viewers would primarily recall facts that cast their side as the aggressor and their antagonists as the victim. Ego-involvement also primed related constructs. Partisans believed that the news coverage would cause neutral viewers to feel more favorably toward their antagonists' ethnic group and perceived that neutral individuals would come to regard their side as the aggressor in the Middle East and their antagonists as the victim.

Yet the results of the second experiment painted a dramatically different picture. The news coverage did not change students' attitudes toward Israel or the PLO; nor did it influence opinions of Jews or Arabs. Furthermore, students primarily remembered random incidents of violence and inhumanity—incidents that they did not associate with either the PLO or Israel. Collectively, these findings extend the third person effect

hypothesis by demonstrating that under highly involving conditions, individuals overestimate the directional influence, as well as the magnitude, of media effects on third persons.

EXPLANATIONS AND PROCESSES

The present results are not compatible with the predictions made by the false consensus hypothesis or a simple projection thesis (Fields & Schuman, 1976). If this alternative hypothesis were correct, partisan subjects would have projected their own interpretations of the news coverage onto neutral individuals. For example, pro-Israeli partisans should have egocentrically concluded that viewers would share their perception that the news coverage displayed a bias against Israel and in favor of the PLO. In a similar fashion, the simple projection thesis would predict that partisans would project their beliefs about how the news coverage influenced them onto neutral viewers. We can only speculate on this question because we did not formally assess partisans' beliefs about how the news coverage influenced their own attitudes. However, their remarks during an extensive posttest interview and their answers to several open-ended questions suggested that partisans came away from the news coverage with, if anything, a strengthened belief in the validity of their cause. According to the simple projection thesis, partisans should have projected this strengthened agreement with their side onto neutral viewers. This should have led partisans to expect that neutral persons would become more favorable toward their side of the conflict. Of course, the results indicated that partisans developed an opposite set of expectations.

Why did partisans come to expect that the news coverage would sway neutral viewers' opinions of their side? One possible interpretation is based on demand characteristics (Orne, 1962). According to this view, partisans guessed the research hypothesis and proceeded to comply with it. However, it strains credulity to argue that partisans were able to differentiate between the simple projection and the hostile media bias hypotheses. Indeed, there was no indication from partisans' written or oral comments that they were aware of the research hypotheses. Instead, as suggested earlier, the findings would seem to reflect the tendency to perceive media coverage as biased against one's side under conditions of high ego-involvement and the general proclivity to overestimate the impact that media reports exert on others.

Although we have some insight into the dynamics of the first mechanism—that is, selective perceptions of media content—we know much less about why individuals tend to exaggerate the impact that mass media exert on others, and if this tendency is more pronounced under highly ego-involving conditions. It is possible that exaggerated beliefs about media impact may have their roots in an acquired script about the gullibility of the mass audience (Smith, 1986)—a script that may be even more persuasive to the extent that the individual's ego-involvement shields the self from the impact of incoming information.

A somewhat different explanation for these findings is suggested by Collins et al.'s (1988) study. These investigators argued that one reason individuals believe that vivid messages exert powerful effects on others is that they assume information that is interesting and attention grabbing is also persuasive. Collins et al. found evidence consistent with this interest-value hypothesis. Applied to the present findings, this interpretation can account for why individuals are inclined to overestimate the size of persuasive message effects; however, it cannot easily explain why Arab and Israeli partisans exaggerated the direction of media effects.

A somewhat elaborated version of this hypothesis would provide an information-processing interpretation of the present findings. According to this view, individuals more closely attend to schema-discrepant information if task conditions allow it (Hastie, 1981). In the present study, partisans might have directed more attention to the schema-discrepant information presented in the news videotape—that is, events that cast their side in a negative light—than to schema-consistent information—material that portrayed their side positively. To the extent that this discrepant information captured their attention, partisans should have regarded it as more interesting and colorful than schema-consistent information. According to the interest value hypothesis, they should have therefore believed that these unfavorable depictions of their side would be more persuasive. Because attention was not assessed in the present study, it is not possible to rule out this hypothesis; however, it should be noted that this interpretation cannot easily account for partisans' perceptions that the news was biased against their side and in favor of their antagonists. Nevertheless, the elaborated version of the interest value hypothesis presents an information-processing view of the third person effect that represents a fruitful avenue for additional research.

ACTUAL EFFECTS

As the second experiment demonstrated, the news coverage did not significantly change students' attitudes toward either Israel or the PLO. These findings are in line with what control-group subjects predicted: They believed that the news videotape would not appreciably influence students' attitudes or beliefs about the Middle East. Unfortunately, this finding can be interpreted in two ways. It is possible that control-group subjects correctly predicted the impact of the news coverage, or it can be argued that they projected their own perceptions of the news coverage onto others.

If there is some ambiguity about the meaning of control-group subjects' predictions, there is, as we have seen, less uncertainty about the nature of partisans' expectations about the news coverage. Yet, if the results of the second experiment might surprise partisans, they should come as little or no surprise to mass communication researchers and scholars of public opinion. There is general agreement that political attitudes are relatively difficult to change, particularly in a one-shot communication experiment (see, for example, Sears & Whitney, 1973). In a similar vein, the results concerning students' recall of vivid news segments are quite compatible with recent findings from news comprehension studies (Robinson & Levy, 1986).

Research is needed to extend the range and domain of the interface between ego-involvement and the third person effect. It would also be useful to determine whether perceptions of media effects mediate the impact that partisanship exerts on attitudes toward the media. For example, do perceptions of hostile media bias underlie extreme distrust of the media (see Gunther & Lasorsa, 1986)? Are they a necessary condition for the occurrence of protests against the media, ranging from liberals' verbal protests against *Amerika* to religious activists' efforts to ban works of fiction from public libraries and schools? It would also be useful to explore other contexts in which ego-involvement influences perceptions of communication effects. One might speculate, for example, that an individual will be more likely to assume that gossip (Rosnow & Fine, 1976) has powerful effects when the gossip focuses on the self than when it concerns other people. Researchers might also explore how perceptions of hostile communication bias can intensify intergroup conflict (Dodge, 1980) and impede efforts at conflict resolution between partisan groups whether they be located in organizations, urban centers, or the fractious Middle East.

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